# GENTLY & FIRMLY




Pratham Books

# GENTLY & FIRMLY

Written by J Neethi Devi

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**GENTLY AND FIRMLY:**

**SHAPING HEARTS AND MINDS**

**J NEETHI DEVI**



# Gently and Firmly

*Shaping Hearts and Minds*



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**J.NEETHI DEVI**



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## INTRODUCTION

Over the past fourteen years, I have witnessed remarkable changes in education, the growing expectations placed on students and the evolving role of teachers. I did not become a teacher by choice, but by chance. Yet, what began as an unexpected profession soon became my greatest passion. Teaching has taught me patience, empathy and the importance of believing in every child.Writing this book allowed me to reflect on the memorable moments I have shared with my students ,their



struggles, dreams, achievements and the lessons they taught me. These experiences strengthened my belief that teaching is not just about imparting knowledge; it is about touching lives. Teaching is not just a profession it is a privilege, a responsibility and above all, a lifelong journey of learning.

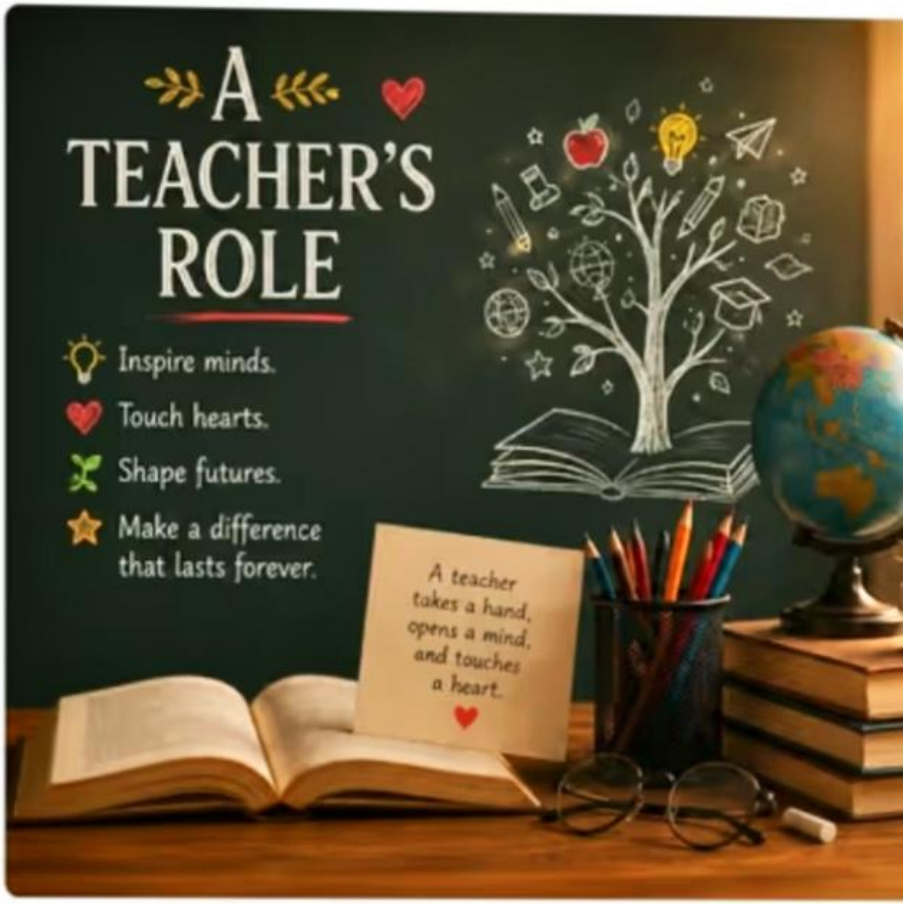
Thanks to my family for their constant support, my wonderful students for their unconditional love and they have been my greatest inspiration,my colleagues who motivated me.

A Teacher's role and how they make a difference.

"If you look behind every exceptional person there is an exceptional teacher."

Stephen Hawking





A Teacher's role and how they make a difference:

Every child needs someone who sees their potential before they see it themselves. A teacher's influence can last longtime.

When I was in Grade 6,I wasn't doing well academically.I struggled in subjects like Mathematics and Science and was unnoticed.I remember my English teacher Ms Josephine who gave me my first opportunity to participate in a stage programme. That changed me forever.The confidence



she instilled in me and the courage to stand before an audience are gift that I still carry with me today.

That's the difference a teacher can make in a student's life. A great teacher recognizes that potential, nurtures it and gives the child the confidence to believe in themselves. The impact of that encouragement stays with them for a lifetime.

Prerana was one such student. I encouraged her to write poetry. She embraced the opportunity and won many competitions.

A New Breed of Teachers.

"The art of teaching is the art of assisting discovery."



A New Breed of Teachers:The role of a teacher is constantly evolving. Today's teachers must embrace a new attitude towards children and teaching. They need to be lifelong learners ready to acquire new skills, adapt to modern teaching methods and use technology to make learning more engaging, relevant and meaningful.

Radhika,a teacher at the age of 49, she stepped out of her comfort zone to learn digital tools such as ChatGPT, Gemini, Canva and other AI tools. Her willingness to learn

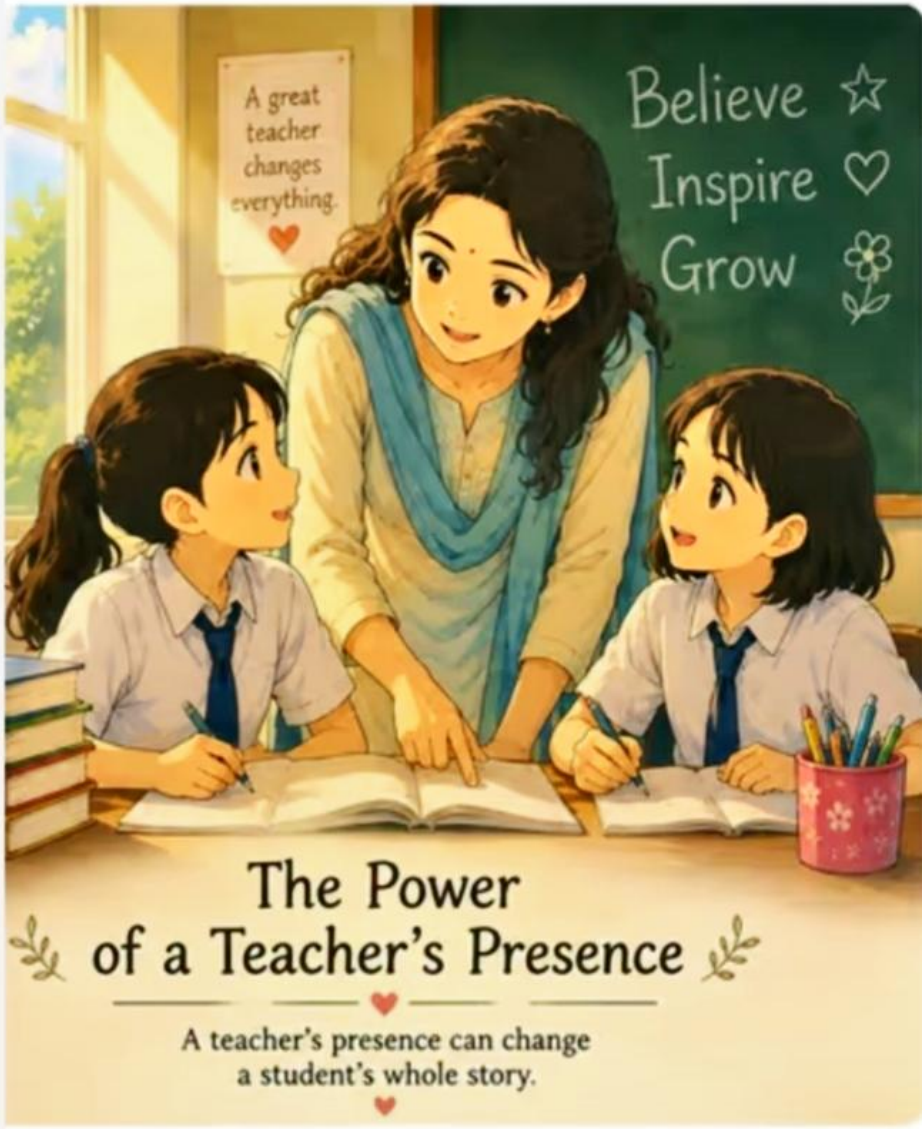


proves that age is never a barrier to growth. Today's students no longer connect with the traditional lecture-only method of teaching. They seek classrooms that are interactive, collaborative and engaging. They enjoy quizzes, debates, group discussions, videos, AI-powered learning and presentations that bring concepts to life. As teachers, we cannot expect our students to embrace change if we are unwilling to change ourselves. When teachers continue to learn, classrooms come alive and students continue to be inspired.

**The Power Of A Teacher's Presence.**

**"AI can support education, but it can never replace the heart of a teacher."**





**The Power of a Teacher's Presence:**

**No matter how much technology changes, nothing can replace a teacher's care, kind words and support. A teacher can encourage a student, build confidence and make a lasting difference in their life.**

**I often give my students a free period just to talk. I don't speak much during that time. I let my students talk and I simply listen. They share their happy moments, their worries, their dreams and the problems they face in school or at home. I also share experiences with them.**



**These conversations help us understand each other and build a strong bond. Sometimes, a student doesn't need advice they just need someone who will listen.**

**A teacher's touch, a teacher's words and a teacher's belief in a student can change a life. AI can answer questions, solve problems and make learning easier but it can never replace a teacher.**

**Technology will continue to grow, but the bond between a teacher and a student can never be replaced.**

Students' Plight.

"Do not train children to learning by force and harshness, but direct them to it by what amuses their minds."

.....by Plato





Student's Plight: Akriti, an eighth grade student. She wakes up at 5:00 a.m. for badminton practice, attends school all day, spends hours at multiple tuition classes, goes to Bharatanatyam lessons and finally gets to bed around 11:00 p.m. This is the reality for many students today.They are expected to excel academically, participate in extracurricular activities, develop new skills and live up to the expectations of parents, teachers and society all while they are still growing up.Teachers and parents must understand



that students needs encouragement and someone who believes in them.

Dear Students,
There is no RIGHT TIME there is only time.Life will never be perfect and the ideal moment may never arrive. What truly matters is making the best use of the time you have today.
There is a beautiful Japanese saying: If you feel like you're losing everything,remember:Trees lose their leaves every year, yet they continue to stand tall, trusting that better days will come.

**Student Well Being.**

**"Educating the mind without educating the heart is no education at all."**

**.....by Aristotle**





**Student Well-being:**

**Dear Parents**

**Never ignore the words of your little ones.**

**A recent news report about a nine-year-old schoolgirl who had allegedly been subjected to bullying by her classmates was heartbreaking. Reports indicated that she had approached her teacher more than once, but her concerns were not addressed with the empathy and urgency they deserved. The young girl later died by s******. Tragically, the incident serves a painful**



**remainder of the devastating impact bullying can have on a child's well-being. Every complaint, every change in a child's behaviour and every cry for help must be taken seriously.**

**Parents should always ask their children about their day at school. They may be silently facing bullying, harassment, loneliness or emotional struggles without telling anyone. A simple conversation can make them feel heard, safe and supported.**

**Teachers and parents play a vital role in a child's well-being. Mental Health matters.**

**Dreams and Aspirations.**

**"Dream, dream, dream. Dreams transform into thoughts and thoughts result in action."**

**by A. P. J Abdul Kalam**





Dreams and Aspirations:"Do not try to do everything. Do one thing well." Parents naturally want the very best for their children and their guidance comes from love and experience. At the same time, the world is changing rapidly. Today, success is no longer limited to a few traditional professions. Opportunities exist in technology, sports, arts, filmmaking, entrepreneurship, research, design and countless other fields.

When Vivan shared with his parents that he wanted to pursue Film Technology, they supported



his decision by enrolling him at the Mumbai Institute of Film Technology. Their trust gave him the confidence to follow his dream.

On the other hand, Rahul completed his Class 10 with a deep passion for becoming an entrepreneur and hoped to build a career in it. However, his parents insisted that he pursue medicine because his father was a doctor.

Students should stay focused on their own journey. Do not compare your path with someone else's. Success is not about following the crowd, work hard and stay committed.

Adoloscence.

"Your time is limited, so don't waste it living someone else's life."





**Adolescence:**

Adolescence is a time of change, curiosity and new emotions. It is natural for students to develop a crush or feel attracted to someone. These feelings are a normal part of growing up, but they should not become a distraction from the goals and responsibilities that shape their future.

Aarav and Anya of Grade 10,who developed a crush on each other. When Anya's parents came to know about it, they decided to move her to another school.

Sneha spent a lot of time texting her



Social Media friends and often neglected studies.

Situations like these can create unnecessary emotional stress and divert students from what should be their primary focus at this stage of life.

A crush may last for a short time, but education, values and personal growth will stay forever. Teenage years are the foundation of future.This time to be utilised to learn, build character, discover strengths and prepare for the opportunities that lie ahead.

Choose your friends wisely.

"You are the average of the five people you spend the most time with."



**Choose Your Friends Wisely:**

The friends you choose can have a big influence on your life. They affect your habits, your attitude, your decisions and your future.

During your school years, friends play an important role in shaping who you become. If you spend time with hardworking, kind and focused friends, you are likely to develop those qualities too. But if you spend most of your time with friends who are careless about their studies, you may slowly pick up those habits as well.

Chetan was a bright



student who did well in academics. But after he started spending time with classmates who were not interested in studying, his focus began to change. His marks dropped and he found it difficult to keep up with his studies.

Unlike Chetan, Pritam chose friends who are hard working like him and had a specific goal.

Choose friends who motivate you, help you grow and bring out the best in you. Good friends will support you, encourage you and stand by you when you need them.

**The Endless Scroll: Use social media responsibly.**

**"The price of anything is the amount of life you exchange for it."**



**The Endless Scroll: Use social media wisely.**

One of the biggest distractions for today's students is the endless scrolling of short videos and reels on social media. What begins as "just five minutes" often turns into hours, taking away valuable time that could be spent learning, reading, exercising or spending time with family.

Excessive screen time can make it harder for some students to concentrate, remember what they have learned and remain



focused on their daily tasks. Many students find themselves constantly checking their phones while studying. Vishna, a Grade 12 student became deeply absorbed in scrolling through reels. She spent hours on social media every day. Later she found it difficult to recall concepts taught in class, struggled to stay focused while studying and often forgot what she had intended to do after walking into another room. It affected not only her studies but also her daily routine.

**AI in Education: A Boon or a Bane?**

**"There are no shortcuts to any place worth going."**





**AI in Education: A Boon or a Bane?**

**Artificial Intelligence has transformed the way we learn and teach. Used wisely, AI is undoubtedly a powerful educational tool.However, it also raises an important question: Is AI becoming a boon or a bane for students?I have noticed that many students are becoming overly dependent on AI for their homework and assignments.**

**Raj of Grade 11 proudly admits that he rarely completes his homework on his own because he relies on AI for almost every task.**



**He jokes that AI has become his best friend.This growing dependence on AI is concerning. Homework is not just about submitting answers; it is about thinking, making mistakes, learning from them and developing problem-solving skills. If AI does all the thinking, students may miss the opportunity to develop these essential abilities. Technology is a wonderful tool when used wisely.Let AI be a guide, a mentor and a learning companion not a substitute for your own thinking and effort.**

**In Conclusion:**

**"Every classroom has a story. Every child has a dream. Every teacher has the power to make both matter."**





**Conclusion:**

**Teachers play a very important role in a child's life. Every child has a story, and every story deserves to be heard. A teacher's job is not just to teach lessons, but also to listen, understand, encourage and support every student.**

**A good teacher is kind, patient, caring, understanding and always ready to learn and grow.**

**Every child deserves a teacher who believes in them before they believe in themselves.**



**A few kind words from a teacher can build a child's confidence, while harsh words can stay in a child's heart for a long time. Sometimes, when students dislike a teacher, they also begin to dislike the subject. Children love their teachers with all their hearts. They look up to them as mentors and often see them as family. They remember not only the lessons taught in class but also the kindness, encouragement and care they receive.**

**A teacher's impact lasts far beyond the classroom.**

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I am an avid reader who enjoys listening to music, singing and watching feel-good movies. I love interacting with people and believe that every conversation is an opportunity to learn something new.

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